

# Psalm 73, You Cannot Aim by Willpower

Roughly 1,300 words. Scripture NIV. The reading plan behind this has five stages and thirteen Pauline cross-references. None of that is in the episode. It is the mine, not the video.

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## 1. The address

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There is a person you want something from that they cannot give you.

Not a favour. Something underneath that. You want them to look at you and settle the question of whether you are real. And you have probably noticed that when they do give you attention it does not settle anything, it lasts about four days, and then you need it again.

That appetite is not a defect. It is standard equipment, and it is enormous, and it was built for something that does not need you and is not lacking. What it does not have is an off switch. If the thing it was made for is unavailable or unrecognised, it does not shut down and wait politely. It goes sideways and installs the nearest available human in the slot.

That is the condition this psalm is about, and the man who wrote it names it in the second line.

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## 2. The text

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Read Psalm 73 whole. All of it, no commentary, no annotation while reading.

Let it sit.

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## 3. The difficulty

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Here is the problem with everything I just said, and it is a serious one.

The standard advice at this point is: desire God more. Want him instead. Redirect your heart.

That is not actionable. It is not even coherent. You cannot want something by deciding to want it. Try it right now with anything, a food you dislike, a person you are not drawn to. Nothing happens. Wanting is not under the control of the will, which is exactly why it runs your life instead of the other way round.

So when someone hands you Psalm 42, as the deer pants for streams of water, so my soul pants for you, my God, and you feel nothing remotely like panting, the psalm does not read as help. It reads as an accusation. Or worse, you say it anyway and you know while you are saying it that you do not mean it, and now you have added dishonesty to the pile.

If the psalms are a device for producing the correct feeling, they fail for the people who need them most, and they turn everyone else into a liar.

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## 4. The turn

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The way out is a fact about desire that the psalter seems to have known three thousand years before anyone wrote it down properly.

Desire is never direct.

You have never once wanted anything by yourself. It always comes through someone. You wanted the job because of the man who had it, the life because of the people living it, the person because of who else wanted them. Girard calls the sideways version of this deviated transcendency, a vertical appetite aimed horizontally, and the reason he matters here is not the vocabulary. It is the consequence.

If desire is always copied, then "want less" is not on the menu and neither is "redirect by force." There has only ever been one lever, and it is not the wanting. It is the model. Who you are looking at.

And the psalter states this as a law. Psalm 115 is talking about idols, the ones with mouths that cannot speak and eyes that cannot see, and then:

**115:8.** "Those who make them will be like them, and so will all who trust in them."

That is not a warning about statues. It is a physics of the person. You become what you look at. Whatever you have installed in the slot is forming you into its own shape right now, whether it is a god, a career, or a specific person who does not know they are carrying this.

Which tells you what a psalm actually is. Not a feeling to be generated. An address to be said. It aims you by putting a direction in your mouth on the days you cannot produce one, and the aiming happens whether or not the feeling has arrived yet.

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## 5. The pressure

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### Test one. Does the psalm actually work that way?

Watch the mechanism in the text.

**73:2-3.** "But as for me, my feet had almost slipped; I had nearly lost my foothold. For I envied the arrogant when I saw the prosperity of the wicked."

He is not describing doubt about doctrine. He is describing envy. He has a model, and it is the wicked, and he is copying them. Sixteen verses of watching them, cataloguing their bodies and their ease and their mouths.

Then:

**73:16-17.** "When I tried to understand all this, it troubled me deeply till I entered the sanctuary of God; then I understood their final destiny."

Read what breaks it. He tried to understand and it troubled him deeply, which is the honest report of a man who reasoned at the problem and got nowhere. The thing that turns it is not an argument. It is a location. He went somewhere. And the seeing changed after the going, not before.

That is the whole method in one verse. He did not think his way out of envy. He changed what was in front of his eyes, and the desire followed the eyes.

### Test two. Then is this just a mood technology?

If the psalms were a device for feeling better, Psalm 88 should not exist.

Read how it ends. Darkness is my closest friend. That is the last line. There is no turn, no resolution, no lifting at the end, and the collection kept it anyway and put it in the book people pray from.

Which tells you the tool is not a mood improver, because a mood improver with a failure case that stark would have been edited. It survived because it is an address. Psalm 88 is a man speaking to God with nothing good to report and no improvement to show, and it is still aimed. The direction is intact even when everything else is gone.

That is the strongest evidence that these things are not about generating a state.

### **Test three. What do you bring on a day you have nothing?**

This is the one that would break it, because a technology that requires you to arrive in a certain condition is useless exactly when you need it.

**51:17.** "My sacrifice, O God, is a broken spirit; a broken and contrite heart you, God, will not despise."

Notice what is being offered. Not repentance completed, not sorrow of the right quality, not a resolution to do better. A broken thing. The entry requirement is that you have nothing, and the verse exists to tell you that nothing is accepted material.

So the tool has no inventory requirement. There is no state you have to reach before you are allowed to use it.

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## **6. The landing**

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The psalm does not end where you expect.

**73:25-26.** "Whom have I in heaven but you? And earth has nothing I desire besides you. My flesh and my heart may fail, but God is the strength of my heart and my portion forever."

He does not say the wicked turned out to be miserable. He does not say he stopped wanting. He says his flesh and his heart may fail, which is a man admitting the appetite is still there and still capable of taking him down, and then he names what it is for.

And here is what this leaves on you.

You are being formed into the shape of something right now. Not eventually, not if you get careless. Now, by whatever is in the slot, according to a law you did not consent to and cannot switch off. The question is never whether you are copying. It is only what.

Which means the thing you have been treating as optional, the saying of words you do not feel on days you have nothing, is not a devotional extra for people who are already doing well.

It is the only lever you have.

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*Open loop, one sentence:* if you become what you look at, the next question is what happens to a man who looks at someone who does not grasp, and that is Philippians 2.